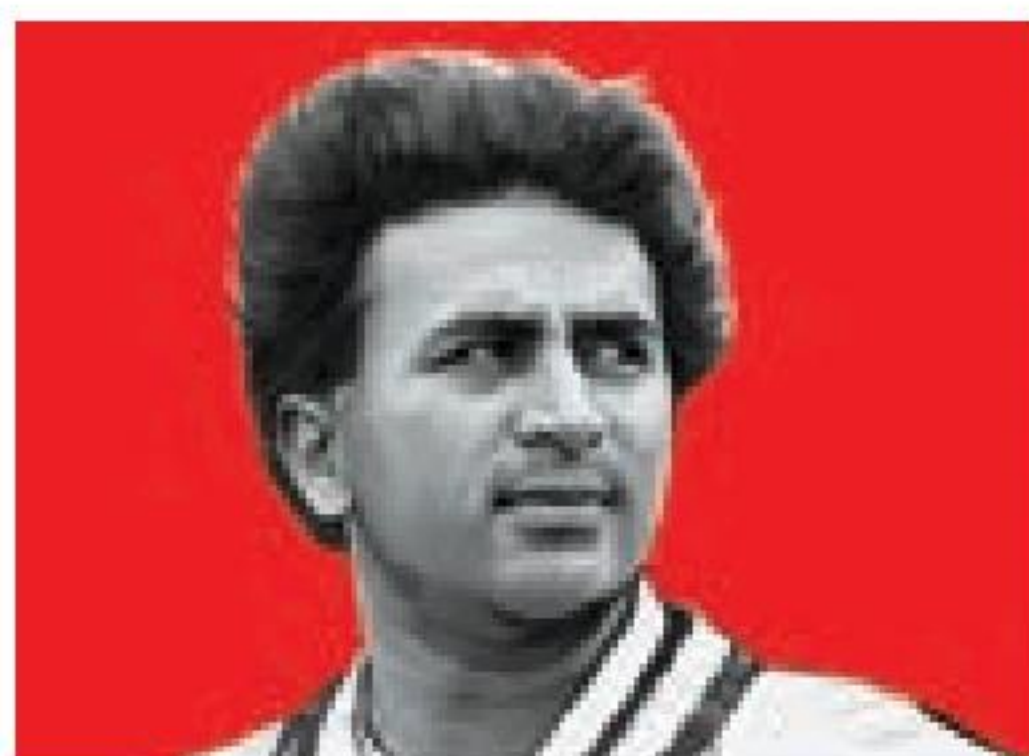




ON THE WRITE LINE

Sunil Gavaskar



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THIS INDIAN TEAM IS CLEARLY THE BEST IN WHITE-BALL CRICKET TODAY

The Indian management must be **congratulated** for their sagacity in showing faith in the squad, and their trust was repaid many times over by the players who were under scrutiny.

There was double anxiety about Sunday's finals. There was the ICC T20 World Cup final in Ahmedabad, and there was the All England Badminton final in Birmingham, England.

The first news wasn't good, with Lakshya Sen losing to Lin Chun-yi to finish runner-up once again. It was his second final at the All England and he missed out again. That said, his effort has to be admired.

In tennis, the majors are spread over two weeks, and men and women play on alternate days in the second week of the tournament.

There is thus a day's break between matches, and even if a men's match has been won in five gruelling sets over many hours, the next day's break does allow the body some recovery time.

In badminton, which is even more energy-sapping and tournaments are played over four or five days, the players are playing every day, and if a

match has gone to three games, then it is really tough for the body to be at 100 per cent the next day.

Lakshya had played all his previous matches for a total of over five hours, and in the semifinals, was beginning to cramp up. No wonder, in the final, he just wasn't able to summon up the energy to combat his opponent.

While the timing of the final was probably more suited for the viewership in China and India, with the match starting around noon in England, it also meant less recovery time for the players, who would have had a tough semifinal the previous day.

Lakshya might want to take a leaf out of Rahul Dravid's book, where the Karnataka and Indian great had his sweat and perspiration analysed to see what he needed to imbibe to lessen the effects of body cramping.

In cricket, which is played in the sun, particularly in India and Australia, the body loses a lot of

sweat and liquid, and replenishing it is essential. Still, full marks to Lakshya for yet another final, and hopefully the winner's medal will be around his neck sooner rather than later.

The gold medals were around the necks of the Suryakumar Yadav-led Indian cricket team for the second consecutive time as they clinched the World Cup with an easy win in the final against New Zealand.

New Zealand have always raised the level of their game in the world competitions. Still, just like it happened last year in the Champions Trophy, they were overwhelmed by an Indian unit that played some extraordinary cricket. With these two wins in the white-ball format, as well as the win in the Asia Cup in between the two ICC competitions, the Indian team is clearly the best white-ball team in the game today.

With players as accomplished as Shubman Gill and Yashasvi Jaiswal unable to find a place in the squad, the depth of talent in Indian cricket is